a pocket field guide to

WILD BUGS

how to spot, identify & (maybe) catch the creatures living in your code

field guides to the digital wild · no. 1

made with ink & off-by-one errors
after the Jargon File · by jerry gay

my sightings

☐ bohrbug

☐ heisenbug

☐ schrödinbug

☐ mandelbug

☐ _____

(new species? name it after yourself.)

please do not release bugs into production. catch & release is **not** recommended.

cut along the dashes

field notes: the first bug

sept 9, 1947. operators of the Harvard Mark II computer found an actual moth stuck in a relay. so they taped it into the logbook.

engineers had already been calling glitches "bugs" for decades. but this one had wings.

the mandelbug

Bugus fractalis

so tangled its cause looks like pure chaos. zoom in: more bug. zoom in again: still bug. it's bugs all the way down.

habitat: systems with 40 microservices

catch difficulty: ★★★★★

how to use this guide

bugs are shy. they hide in the one line you were *sure* was fine.

pack: ☐ a rubber duck ☐ snacks ☐ patience

leave at home: the deadline

the bohrbug

Bugus reliabilis

the friendly one. shows up every single time, in the same spot, like a good dog. honestly? kind of a sweetheart.

habitat: loops with < where you meant <=

catch difficulty: ★☆☆☆☆

the heisenbug

Bugus observatus-fugit

vanishes the moment you look at it. add a print statement: gone. delete the print statement: back. it knows.

habitat: race conditions, timing, 3am

catch difficulty: ★★★★☆

the schrödinbug

Bugus dormiens

sleeps in old code for years. then someone reads it and says "wait, how did this ever work?" and it stops working. immediately.

habitat: legacy code nobody dares to touch

catch difficulty: ★★★☆☆